

LESSON 16

LETTERS

Outline

- Letters
- Types of Letters
- Format of Letters
- Elements of Letters
- Job Application Letters
- Structure of Letters
- Transmittal Letters

Letters

Business letters are formal letters used for business-to-business, business-to-client, or client-to-business correspondence. There are a number of elements to a business letter. Letters are used to communicate outside your organization. Whereas the memorandum is the primary vehicle for communication within an organization, letters are often used to communicate to individuals outside it, especially in formal and semiformal contexts.

Types of Letters

The following are some of the most common types of letters written by people in technical fields:

- Job application letters
- Acceptance letters
- Transmittal letters
- Inquiry letters
- Technical-information letters
- Letters of recommendation

Format of Letter

If your organization has a specific style for business letters, follow that format. Otherwise, follow the guidelines provided here. Business letters are commonly either full-block formatted, with every line starting at the left margin and usually a business letterhead at the top of the page, or modified-block, formatted with the heading and the closing aligned at the center of the page.

Elements of Letter

Business letters have the following elements:

- Heading
- Date
- Recipient's address
- Salutation
- Body

- Closing
- End notations

- **Heading**

If you are using letterhead stationery, include only the date two lines below the bottom of the letterhead. Spell out the name of month.

- **Recipient's Address**

Two to four lines below the date, place the following items:

The recipient's title (such as *Mr.*, *Ms.*, or *Dr.*) and full name (address a woman who does not have a professional title as *Ms.* unless you know she prefers *Miss* or *Mrs.*; if the recipient does not have a title and you are unsure of his or her gender, omit the title).

You need to include the following:

- The recipient's job title, if appropriate.
- The name of the company or institution, if appropriate.
- The full address, following the same format as for the address in the heading.
- The recipient's address is always aligned on the left margin.

- **Salutation**

Place the salutation two lines below the recipient's address. The salutation begins with the word *Dear*, continues with the recipient's title and last name, and ends with a colon.

- **Body**

Start the letter two lines after the salutation. Body paragraphs should be single spaced with a double space between paragraphs. Indenting the first line of each paragraph is acceptable but is more informal than the unintended style.

- **Closing Phrase**

Write a complimentary closing phrase two lines below the final body paragraph.

Yours truly, *Sincerely*, or *Sincerely yours* are common endings for professional letters.

Capitalize the first letter of the first word of your complimentary closing and end the complimentary closing with a comma.

- **End Notations**

At the bottom of the last page of a business letter, 'End Notations' may show who typed the letter, whether any material is enclosed with the letter, and who is receiving a copy of the letter.

Example

Enclosure: Article by Ali Bashir

Encl. (2)

Enc. (2)

Example

cc: Dr. Maria Aalam
Mr. Waleed Usman

Template of Business Letter

Your Phone Number

Your Email Address

Date

Contact Information

Name

Title

Company

Address

City, State, Zip Code

Salutation

Dear Mr./Ms. Last Name:

Body of Business Letter

Keep your letter simple and focused, so the purpose of your letter is clear.

The first paragraph of your business letter should provide an introduction to why you are writing. Then, in the following paragraphs provide more information and details about your request.

The final paragraph should reiterate the reason you are writing and thank the reader for reviewing your request. Single space your letter and justify your letter to the left. Leave a blank line between each paragraph.

Complimentary Close

Respectfully yours,

Signature

Handwritten Signature (for a mailed letter)

Typed Signature

Job Application Letters

While writing a job application letter, identify a specific area of employment, summarize your qualifications for the job, refer to an enclosed résumé, and request the next step of the application process, usually an interview.

Application letters

Application letters are usually just one page and consist of three sections:

- Front Matter
- Body
- End Matter

- **Front Matter**

State that you are applying for a specific job title or field. Also mention the person who referred you or told you about the job. If you learned of the job from an advertisement, mention that.

- **Body**

Explain specifically why you are qualified for the job. Describe education, work experience, and any other activity that display relevant talents, such as foreign-language proficiencies and leadership or supervisory experience.

- **End Matter**

Refer to your enclosed résumé and express your desire for an interview, stating when and where you will be available for one. In addition, invite further inquiries, and state how you can be contacted.

For sample 'Job Application Letter', please view the following link:

<http://jobsearch.about.com/od/morejobletters/a/jobappletter.htm>

Acceptance Letters

Letters accepting a job not only convey information, but also establish a contractual relationship between you and the organization or person offering you the position.

Consequently, acceptance letters should accurately restate the key terms of employment.

Format

Begin the first paragraph by enthusiastically accepting the job. Be sure to state the exact title of the job and the salary. The second paragraph usually discusses details about the position, especially the date that you will begin work from.

For sample 'Acceptance Letter', please view the following link:

http://www.eduers.com/resume/Acceptance_Letters.htm

Transmittal Letters

A transmittal or cover letter accompanies a larger item, usually a document. The transmittal letter provides the recipient with a specific context in which to place the larger document and simultaneously gives the sender a permanent record of having sent the material.

For sample 'Transmittal Letter', please view the following link:

<http://writing.colostate.edu/guides/documents/ce-trpt/pop9j.cfm>

LESSON 17

LETTERS II

Outline

- Letter of Inquiry
- Sample of Inquiry Letter
- Technical-Information Letters and Memoranda
- References and Letters of Recommendation
- Guidelines for Writing References
- Guidelines for Writing Letters of recommendation

Letters of Inquiry

A letter of inquiry asks someone for specific information. In some cases, such as a request for promotional material, the recipient will have a clear interest in responding to your letter. In other cases, such as a request for specific information on a product, the recipient may or may not be as motivated to respond quickly. Consequently, always make the tone of the letter friendly and make it easy for the recipient to identify and provide the information you need.

Sample of Inquiry Letter

The following letter of inquiry is written by a computer programmer, requesting specific information about an upcoming release of a software product.

Head:

Arlington Heights Programming Associates
16 Oak Street
Springfield, CA 90467

November 11, 1996

Customer Relations
Turing Data Solutions
2345 Maple Avenue
Mountain View, CA 94941

Dear Customer Relations:

Body:

I am a systems engineer at Arlington Heights Programming Associates developing a new client-server networked database system for two non-profit corporations.

My team is considering using your new release of Omega Database Plus 1.0 as a key part of the system. If we incorporate your product into our design, our clients will need to purchase at least a total of 140 copies of your software.

We have read your promotional material and are very interested in using your product. We need, however, the answers to the following questions before we can decide whether or not to use Omega Database Plus:

1. Are you still planning to release the Omega Database Plus Version 1.0 on February 12, 1998?
2. What LAN environments will your product support?
3. Will your product support PGP encryption?

Footer

I would be happy to talk to you further about your product. You can call me at (415) 666-4323 or e-mail me at egarrels@arpro.com.

Sincerely,

Edgar Garrels
Senior Systems Engineer

cc: Mr. R. Williams

Technical-Information Letters and Memoranda

Technical-information letters and memoranda are short documents that announce new technical information, such as a software bug and its solution, or a new feature. Use the memorandum format if the information is being sent inside an organization. Use the letter format if the document will be sent to outside individuals.

Body

The addressing scheme for the World Wide Web relies on Uniform Resource Locators (URLs). Each Web document has a URL, which identifies the protocol being used, the name of the Web server the document is on, and the path name to get to the document. (Note: in common usage, the more specific term “Uniform Resource Locator (URL),” is frequently used where the more general term “Universal Resource Indicator (URI)” would be more appropriate.)

A URL must indicate the protocol, Web server, and path name (e.g., “<http://web.mit.edu/cwis/faq/shorturl.html>”) as opposed to a relative URL, which assumes the same protocol and server, and just gives the path relative to the location of the current document (e.g., “[./comments.html](#)”). A URI can be either a URL or a relative URL. One problem with URLs is that they can become long and unwieldy.

MIT Information Systems has come up with a scheme for shorter URLs for files stored on the Athena network and accessed through the Web server, web.mit.edu. Since electronic publishers at MIT can now use and publicize shorter URLs for their documents, addresses will be easier to reference and remember. In the past, for example, to get the *Technology Review* home page, you had to enter the following URL in your Web browser:

<http://web.mit.edu/afs/athena/org/t/techreview/www/index.html>

References and Letters of Recommendation

A letter of recommendation is a letter that makes a statement of support for a candidate. The writer assesses the qualities, characteristics, and capabilities of the person being recommended in terms of that individual’s ability to perform a particular task or function. Letters of recommendation are typically related to employment, admissions to institutions of higher education or scholarship eligibility.

References are an essential component of almost all admissions, grant, and employment processes. Managers and other individuals in any selection process need evaluations from individuals who have had long and close contact with applicants in order to assess accurately their abilities and accomplishments.

The number of recommendations required by employers and universities usually ranges from one to five, with three being the most common number.

- **Obtaining Letters of Recommendation**

Make your candidacy as strong as possible by carefully soliciting references and letters of recommendation. Letters of recommendation are extremely important in decisions to hire, admit an individual, and to award a scholarship or grant.

- **General Guidelines for Requesting References or Letters of Recommendation**

If possible, always ask one or two more persons than the minimum number you need.

Ask a range of persons who can testify to different abilities and accomplishments relevant to the position or award.

If possible, ask someone in person to write a recommendation or to be a reference. If the individual is far away, ask him or her by phone or through a written letter. Generally, unless you know the person extremely well, do not ask someone to be a reference or write a letter of recommendation through e-mail.

- **Guidelines for Written Letters of Recommendation**

Generally, people give more weight to recommendations that contain a waiver of your right to see the recommendation. Sometimes, however, it may be prudent not to waive your right to review the recommendation, especially if you are unsure of the recommender's attitude toward you or his writing ability.

Recommenders are busy people; give them all the necessary material at least three weeks before the recommendation is due.

- **Writing Letters of Recommendation**

Write letters of recommendation to provide relevant information and to present an individual truthfully and positively.

- **Guidelines for Writing Letters of Recommendation**

In most cases, agree to write a letter of recommendation only if you can honestly write a supportive letter. If you cannot portray an individual positively, decline to write the recommendation.

Ask for a current Résumé, and as complete a description as possible of the position or program to which the person is applying. Assemble and review all other relevant information you may have about the person you are recommending. It is often easy to overlook some important accomplishment. In most cases, a letter of recommendation should consist of three or four paragraphs and not be over one page in length.

For sample 'Recommendation Letters', please view the following link:

<http://businessmajors.about.com/od/samplerecommendations/a/RecSample4.htm>
<http://www.eduers.com/images/sample-letter-of-recommendation.gif>